

COUPLE GOALS The Roys at their house in Tilonia

PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR

Barefoot College began as a deceptively simple idea. In the early 1970s, Sanjit 'Bunker' Roy—an alumnus of The Doon School and St Stephen's College—set out to address water scarcity in India's most arid regions. A relative at Mayo College in Ajmer advised him to begin in Rajasthan. Roy chose Tilonia, a village in Ajmer district, and started by educating locals about water harvesting and conservation.

It was during this work that Roy encountered a persistent rural problem: when hand pumps or tubewells broke down, villages often waited weeks for a mechanic to arrive from a town. Roy began repairing pumps himself to demonstrate that such skills could be learned locally. If villagers could repair bicycles or work as ironsmiths, he reasoned, they could also handle basic mechanical tasks—if they were trained.

With government support, Roy was allotted an abandoned tuberculosis hospital building in Tilonia, which became the Barefoot College campus. A three-month residential training programme was launched to train barefoot mechanics—crucially including women. Initially, the government was reluctant to waive minimum education qualifications for technicians, but soon enough Barefoot College's early success persuaded authorities to relax norms and eventually extend the model across Rajasthan.

Soon enough, the college expanded beyond water and mechanics. To address teacher shortages, Barefoot College trained Class 8–pass women and Class 10–pass men to teach children up to Class 5. Over time, children outnumbered adults in classrooms, and the programme evolved into a scalable model of community-led primary education.

FOUNDERSPEAK

"It is not easy to persuade women to leave home for six weeks to three months of residential training, but most of them return empowered and bring lasting happiness to their families"

SANJIT BUNKER ROY, *Founder*

Healthcare became another pillar. Locally trained health workers provided basic services in villages where doctors were scarce. Alongside this, Roy's wife, social activist Aruna Roy, played a key role in mobilising women and developing Tilonia's now-recognisable handicrafts—parrots, bells and other artefacts—eventually expanding into carpentry, weaving and leatherwork.

Barefoot College, meanwhile, continued to evolve. In later years, it took on solar energy—long before it became mainstream in rural India. Women, including those with little or no formal education, were trained as solar engineers through residential programmes. "I dropped out of school after Class 3 and never imagined doing a formal job," says 59-year-old Leela Devi, a master trainer. "I joined Barefoot College 23 years ago, learnt solar technology, trained women from 96 countries, and have travelled to four countries." As solar adoption grew, women from other states in India as well as in some African countries joined Tilonia for training.

Today, under the guidance of Roy and the supervision of CEO Sowmya Kidambi, Barefoot College is working closely with governments. Recently, it signed an MoU with the Rajasthan government to advance the prime minister's Solar Sakhi programme. "With the massive expansion of solar energy, our aim—along with the government—is to train as many people as possible in remote areas so that local solutions are available when problems arise," she says. And with women constituting half the workforce across programmes, there seems to be no stopping this revolution. ■